

Y. HELENA LIU

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Citizenship: Canada

RESEARCH POSITIONS

Assistant Professor (Incoming), University of Toronto Department of Psychology	2027
Postdoctoral Research Associate, Princeton University Computational Neuroscience; Advisor: Jonathan Pillow	2024 – present
Graduate Research Fellow, University of Washington Computational Neuroscience; Advisor: Eric Shea-Brown	2020 – 2024
Visiting Research Collaborator, MIT McGovern Institute	2023
Research Intern, Mila – Quebec AI Institute	2021 – 2023
Visiting Scientist, Allen Institute for Brain Science	2020 – 2023

EDUCATION

PhD, Applied Mathematics, University of Washington (UW)	2024
MASc, Electrical and Computer Engineering, University of Toronto (U of T)	2019
BASc, Engineering Science (Electrical and Computer Option), U of T	2017

HONORS AND AWARDS

Rising Stars in Data Science (Stanford University)*	2025
Rising Stars in Engineering in Health (Columbia University)	2025
Rising Stars in EECS (MIT)	2024
Boeing Teaching Award: 300 USD	2024
FRQNT Postdoctoral Research Fellowship: 90000 CAD (ranked 1st)	2024 – 2026
Selected Participant, Rising Stars in Computational & Data Sciences (UT Austin)	2024
IVADO Postdoctoral Fellowship: 210000 CAD (offered, but declined)	2024
NSERC Postdoctoral Fellowship: 90000 CAD (offered, but declined)	2024
Carl E. Pearson Fellowship: 37000 USD**	2023 – 2024
FRQNT Doctoral Research Fellowship: 25000 CAD	2023 – 2024
FRQNT Doctoral Research Fellowship Supplement: 1500 CAD	2023 – 2024
Weill Neurohub and NeuroTEC Travel Award: 500 USD	2023
Mitacs Globalink Research Award: 6000 CAD	2023
NeurIPS Scholar Award: 1748 USD	2022
NSF AccelNet IN-BIC Exchange Fellowship: 10000 USD	2022
Boeing Research Award: 500 USD	2021
NSF AccelNet IN-BIC Exchange Fellowship: 8400 USD	2021
NSERC Postgraduate Scholarship (PGS D3): 63000 CAD	2020 – 2023
Queen Elizabeth II Graduate Scholarship: 15000 CAD	2018 – 2019
Ontario Graduate Scholarship: 15000 CAD	2017 – 2018

Engineering Science Capstone Design Winner, U of T: 1500 CAD	2017
Engineering Society Award, U of T: 4200 CAD	2015
NSERC Undergraduate Summer Research Award: 5600 CAD	2014
Club for Biomedical Engineering Competition Winner, U of T: 300 CAD	2014
Tetra Enable Competition Potential Award, U of T: 200 CAD	2013

*= Selected to the Rising Stars in Data Science cohort; unable to attend

**= Administered by the UW Applied Mathematics Department and has been awarded to only three individuals in the department's history, including myself, at the NSF GRFP rate (adjusted based on the FRQNT support)

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

- Liu Y.H.**, Geadah V., Pillow J., “Flexible inference of learning rules from de novo learning data using neural networks”. *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*, 2025.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Baratin A., Cornford J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “How connectivity structure shapes rich and lazy learning in neural circuits”, *International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)*, 2024.
- Liu Y.H.**, Ghosh A., Richards B. A., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “Beyond accuracy: generalization properties of bio-plausible temporal credit assignment rules”, *NeurIPS*, 2022.
- Liu Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “Cell-type-specific neuromodulation guides synaptic credit assignment in a spiking neural network”, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*, 2021.

FULL PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS LIST

- [P1] **Liu Y.H.**, Geadah V., Pillow J., “Flexible inference of learning rules from de novo learning data using neural networks”. *NeurIPS*, 2025.
- [P2] **Liu Y.H.**, Yang R.G., Cueva C.J., “Can Biologically Plausible Temporal Credit Assignment Rules Match BPTT for Neural Similarity? E-prop as an Example”, *International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)*, 2025.
– Earlier version appeared as: “Multiple temporal credit assignment rules achieve comparable neural data similarity”, *NeuroAI at NeurIPS Workshop*, 2024.
- [P3] Ghosh M., Habashy K.G., De Santis F., Fiers T., ..., **Liu, Y.H.**, ..., Goodman F., “Spiking neural network models of sound localisation via a massively collaborative process”, *eNeuro*, 2025.
- [P4] Liu W., Zhang X., **Liu, Y.H.**, “The Influence of Initial Connectivity on Biologically Plausible Learning”, *AI to Accelerate Science and Engineering at the Association for the Advancement of Artificial Intelligence (AAAI)*, 2025.
- [P5] **Liu, Y.H.**, Baratin A., Cornford J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “How connectivity structure shapes rich and lazy learning in neural circuits”, *International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)*, 2024.
- [P6] Ghosh A., **Liu Y.H.**, Lajoie G., Kording K., Richards B. A., “How gradient estimator variance and bias impact learning in neural networks”, *ICLR*, 2023.
- [P7] **Liu Y.H.**, Ghosh A., Richards B. A., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “Beyond accuracy: generalization properties of bio-plausible temporal credit assignment rules”, *NeurIPS*, 2022.

- [P8] **Liu Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “Biologically-plausible backpropagation through arbitrary timespans via local neuromodulators”, *NeurIPS*, 2022.
- [P9] **Liu Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “Cell-type-specific neuromodulation guides synaptic credit assignment in a spiking neural network”, *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*, 2021.
- [P10] **Liu Y.**, Grigorovsky V., Bardakjian B., “Excitation and inhibition balance underlying epileptiform activity,” *Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) Transaction on Biomedical Engineering*, 2020.
- [P11] Jacobs D., **Liu Y.H.**, Hilton T., del Campo M., Carlen P.L., Bardakjian B.L., “Classification of scalp EEG states prior to clinical seizure onset,” *IEEE Journal of Translational Engineering in Health and Medicine*, 2019.
- [P12] **Liu Y.**, Khisti A., Mahajan A., “On privacy in smart metering systems with periodically time-varying input distribution,” *Proceedings of IEEE Global Conference on Signal and Information Processing*, 2017.
- [P13] **Liu Y.H.**, Lee S-H., Khisti A., “Information-theoretic privacy in smart metering systems using cascaded rechargeable batteries,” *IEEE Signal Processing Letters*, 2017.

PREPRINTS

- [P14] Mastrovito D., **Liu, Y.H.**, Kusmierz L., Shea-Brown E., Koch C., Mihalas S., “Transition to chaos separates learning regimes and relates to measure of consciousness in recurrent neural networks”, *bioRxiv*, 2024.
- [P15] Hazelden J., **Liu, Y.H.**, Shlizerman E., Shea-Brown E., “Evolutionary algorithms as an alternative to backpropagation for supervised training of biophysical neural networks and neural ODEs”, *arXiv*, 2023.

TEACHING, MENTORING, AND CURRICULUM DESIGN

Instructor of Record

- | | |
|--|-------------------|
| • Introduction to Neural Coding and Computation, UW (upper-division, ~70 students) | 01/2024 – 03/2024 |
| • Applied Linear Algebra and Numerical Analysis, UW (upper-division, ~50 students) | 06/2022 – 08/2022 |

Research Mentoring

- | | |
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| | 04/2023 – present |
| • Weixuan Liu, Computer Science Undergraduate | 04/2023 – 05/2024 |
| • Rita Zhang, Mathematics Undergraduate | 04/2023 – 05/2024 |
| • Hanson Mo, Physics Undergraduate | 10/2023 – present |

Course Design Assistant*, Neuromatch Academy

04/2023 – 07/2023

Guest Lecturer

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| • Mathematical Biology, Whitworth University (Liberal Arts College) | 01/2024 |
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Teaching Assistant

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| • COSYNE Tutorial on Spiking Neural Networks (graduate/professional audience) | 03/2022 |
| • Calculus with Analytic Geometry, UW (lower-division, 100+ students) | 09/2019 – 12/2020 |
| • Fundamentals of Computer Programming, U of T (lower-division, 100+ students) | 01/2019 – 04/2019 |
| • Linear Algebra, U of T | 09/2018 – 12/2018 |

- (lower-division, 100+ students)
- Calculus III, U of T 09/2018 – 12/2018
(lower-division, 100+ students)
- Introduction to Computer Programming, U of T 09/2017 – 12/2017
(lower-division, 100+ students)

* Designed teaching tools based on **large language models (LLMs)** to provide expanded explanations on course material and to guide students through coding exercises

INVITED TALKS

Recent Advances in AI and Statistical Methods for Neuroscience, EcoSta	08/2026
Behavioral modeling group meeting, New York University	05/2026
Haverford/Bryn Mawr Bi-College Colloquium, Haverford College	04/2026
Princeton Neuroscience Institute Lunch Seminar at Princeton University	09/2025
Center for Statistics and Machine Learning at Princeton University	12/2024
Kempner Institute at Harvard University	12/2023
Neural Theory Group at the University of Oregon	11/2023
The Center for the Physics of Biological Function at Princeton University	11/2023
MetaConscious Group at MIT McGovern Institute	10/2023
Grossman Center at the University of Chicago	10/2023
Pillow Lab at Princeton University	10/2023
NeuralAI reading group at Mila – Quebec AI Institute	10/2022
UW Neural Computation and Engineering Connection	05/2022
International Network for Bio-Inspired Computing	04/2022
Lajoie Group at Mila – Quebec AI Institute	09/2021
Summer Workshop on the Dynamic Brain at the Allen Institute	08/2021

ACCEPTED ORAL PRESENTATIONS

- Liu, Y.H.**, Geadah V., Pillow J., “Flexible inference of learning rules from de novo learning data using neural networks”, Statistical Analysis of Neural Data (SAND), 2025.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Baratin A., Cornford J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “How connectivity structure shapes rich and lazy learning in neural circuits”, NeuroAI Montreal, 2023.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “Biologically-plausible backpropagation through arbitrary timespans via local neuromodulators,” Computational and Systems Neuroscience (COSYNE), 2023.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Ghosh A., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “Beyond accuracy: robustness and generalization properties of biologically plausible learning rules,” From Neuroscience to Artificially Intelligent Systems (NAISys), 2022.
- Liu, Y.H.**, “A Large-Scale Neuro-Glial Network Model of Seizure Termination,” U of T Annual Research Conference, 2019.

ACCEPTED POSTER PRESENTATIONS

- Liu, Y.H.**, Geadah V., Pillow J., “Flexible inference of history-dependent learning rules in de novo learning”, Cognitive Computational Neuroscience (CCN), 2026.

- Liu, Y.H.**, Geadah V., Pillow J., “Flexible inference of animal learning rules using neural networks”, COSYNE, 2026.
- Mo H. H., **Liu Y.H.**, Shea-Brown E., Mihalas S., “How spiking vs rate dynamics in neural networks impact rich vs lazy learning regimes”, 10th Annual BRAIN Initiative Meeting, 2024.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Baratin A., Cornford J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “How connectivity structure shapes rich and lazy learning in neural circuits”, COSYNE, 2024.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Baratin A., Cornford J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “How recurrent network connectivity shapes learning: implications for effective rich and lazy regimes in neuroscience”, Lake Conference – Neural Coding and Dynamics, 2023.
- Liu Y.H.**, Ghosh A., Richards B. A., Shea-Brown E., Lajoie G., “Beyond accuracy: generalization properties of bio-plausible temporal credit assignment rules”, 9th Annual BRAIN Initiative Meeting, 2023.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “Biologically-plausible backpropagation through arbitrary timespans via local neuromodulators,” NeuroAI in Seattle, 2022.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Lajoie G., “Beyond accuracy: robustness and generalization properties of biologically plausible learning rules,” COSYNE, 2022.
- Liu, Y.H.**, Smith S.J., Mihalas S., Shea-Brown E., Sumbul U., “A solution to temporal credit assignment using cell-type-specific modulatory signals,” COSYNE, 2021.

SERVICE AND OUTREACH

Reviewer , CCN 2026 (reviewed 4 submissions)	05/2026
Reviewer , PNAS	04/2026
Reviewer , Science Advances	04/2026
Reviewer , NeurIPS 2025 (reviewed 3 submissions)	06/2025 – 08/2025
Reviewer , ICML 2025 (reviewed 6 submissions)	02/2025 – 04/2025
Reviewer , COSYNE 2025 (reviewed 10 submissions)	11/2024
Reviewer , ICLR 2024 (reviewed 3 submissions)	10/2024 – 12/2024
Co-organizer , COSYNE 2024 Workshop	01/2024 – 03/2024
Reviewer , COSYNE 2024 (reviewed 10 submissions)	12/2023
Secretary , UW Association for Women in Mathematics	09/2023 – 05/2024
Reviewer , NeurIPS 2023 (reviewed 6 submissions)	06/2023 – 08/2023
Session Chair , UW Neural Computation and Engineering Connection	05/2023
Outreach Volunteer , SIAM Math Fair at Lockwood Elementary School	05/2023
Reviewer , COSYNE 2023 (reviewed 12 submissions)	12/2022
Panelist , UW SIAM Student Chapter	10/2020 – 12/2023
Student Organizer , Fairhall and Shea-Brown Joint Lab Meetings	01/2022 – 06/2022
Student Organizer , UW Theoretical Neuroscience Journal Club	09/2020 – 06/2021
Mentor , UW Amath Student Mentorship Program	07/2020 – 06/2022
Event Director , U of T IEEE Student Chapter	09/2016 – 04/2017
Co-Chair , U of T Engineering Science Education Conference	03/2015 – 02/2016
Executive , U of T Undergrad Engineering Research Day	05/2014 – 08/2014

NEWS COVERAGE

"Complex Wiring in Neural Networks," College of Arts and Sciences, University of Washington, December 2021. Available at: <https://tinyurl.com/mr36cvjz>

BLOG WRITING

"Generalization properties of bio-plausible temporal credit assignment rules." The Mila Blog (June 2023), URL: <https://tinyurl.com/4hz6uvs9>

ADDITIONAL TRAINING

<i>Mentoring Best Practices</i> , Princeton Neuroscience Institute	01/2025 – 04/2025
<i>Summer Workshop on the Dynamic Brain</i> , Allen Institute for Brain Science	08/2021
<i>Scientific Writing</i> , Faculty of Applied Science and Engineering, U of T	01/2019 – 04/2019

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Proficiency in Python (NumPy, Matplotlib, TensorFlow, PyTorch), MATLAB, C/C++, shell scripting and working with supercomputers.

Last updated: August 22, 2026